Chapter 8 — Maps, Sets, Iterators and Generators

Plain objects and arrays can do a lot, but two jobs come up so often that JavaScript has dedicated collections for them: **looking things up by key** (`Map`) and **keeping values unique** (`Set`). This chapter covers both, their "weak" cousins that don't cause memory leaks, and then the machinery that makes `for…of`, spread and destructuring work on all of them — the **iteration protocols** — and **generators**, the easiest way to produce your own lazy sequences. We finish with the newest additions: **iterator helpers** (ES2025) and `Object.groupBy` / `Map.groupBy` (ES2024).

What you'll learn

1. `Map`: creating, `set` / `get` / `has` / `delete` / `clear` / `size`, iterating, converting, and when to prefer it over an object.
2. `Set`: uniqueness, methods, iteration, and the ES2025 set-algebra methods (`union`, `intersection`, …).
3. `WeakMap`, `WeakSet`, `WeakRef` and `FinalizationRegistry`: holding objects without keeping them alive.
4. The **iterable** and **iterator** protocols, `Symbol.iterator`, and everything that consumes iterables.
5. **Generators** (`function*`, `yield`, `yield*`), lazy and infinite sequences, two-way communication, async generators.
6. **Iterator helpers** (`map`, `filter`, `take`, `drop`, `flatMap`, `reduce`, `toArray`, …) and `Iterator.from`.
7. **Grouping** with `Object.groupBy` and `Map.groupBy`.

`Before you start.` You should know objects (Chapter 5), arrays and their callback methods (Chapter 7), and closures (Chapter 4). One example uses a class with `#private` fields, explained in Chapter 9; async generators use promises, explained in Chapter 12.

All code is in `code/`; outputs are real, from Node 24.

8.1 `Map`

What it is

A `Map` (ES2015) is a collection of **key → value** pairs, like an object used as a dictionary, but designed for that job:

- **Keys can be any value** — objects, functions, numbers, `NaN` — not only strings and symbols.
- It **remembers insertion order**, always.
- It knows its own `size`.
- It is **directly iterable** with `for…of`.

Think of a coat-check counter: you hand over *anything* as a ticket (the key) and get back exactly the coat stored under it.

How it works — creating a Map

`new Map()` creates an empty map. Optionally pass an **iterable of `[key, value]` pairs** (for example an array of two-element arrays) to fill it.

From `code/01_map.mjs`:

```
const stock = new Map([
  ['apples', 500],
  ['bananas', 300],
  ['oranges', 200],
]);
console.log(stock, stock.size);
```

Output:

```
Map(3) { 'apples' => 500, 'bananas' => 300, 'oranges' => 200 } 3
```

Properties and methods

Member	What it does	Returns
`size` (property)	Number of entries	number
`set(key, value)`	Adds a new entry or **updates** an existing key	the map itself (so calls chain)
`get(key)`	Looks up a key	the value, or `undefined` if absent
`has(key)`	Checks whether the key exists	boolean
`delete(key)`	Removes one entry	`true` if something was removed, else `false`
`clear()`	Removes all entries	`undefined`
`keys()` / `values()` / `entries()`	Iterators over keys / values / `[key, value]` pairs, in insertion order	iterator
`forEach((value, key, map) => …, thisArg?)`	Calls a function per entry, in insertion order	`undefined`
`[Symbol.iterator]()`	Same as `entries()` – why `for (const [k, v] of map)` works	iterator
`Map.groupBy(items, fn)` (static, ES2024)	Builds a Map of groups (section 8.7)	Map

```
const books = new Map();
books.set('1984', 'George Orwell').set('Dune', 'Frank Herbert');   // set returns the map -> chainable
console.log(books.get('1984'), books.get('Missing'), books.has('Dune'));
books.set('Dune', 'F. Herbert');                                   // same key -> update
console.log(books.size, books.delete('Dune'), books.delete('Dune'), books.size);
```

Output:

```
George Orwell undefined true
2 true false 1
```

Keys of any type

Map compares keys with **SameValueZero**: like `===`, except `NaN` equals `NaN` (and `+0` equals `-0`). Object keys are matched **by reference** – a different object with the same contents is a different key.

```
const m = new Map();
const objKey = { id: 1 };
const fnKey = () => {};
m.set(objKey, 'object as key').set(fnKey, 'function as key').set(1, 'number 1').set('1', 'string 1').set(NaN,
'NaN works');
console.log(m.get(objKey), m.get(fnKey), m.get(1), m.get('1'), m.get(NaN), m.get({ id: 1 }));

const o = {};
o[objKey] = 'x'; o[1] = 'number'; o['1'] = 'string overwrites';
console.log(Object.keys(o), o);
```

Output:

```
object as key function as key number 1 string 1 NaN works undefined
[ '1', '[object Object]' ] { '1': 'string overwrites', '[object Object]': 'x' }
```

With a plain object, every key is converted to a string: the object key becomes the useless `'[object Object]'` (so *all* objects would share one slot), and `1` and `'1'` collide. The Map keeps them distinct.

Iterating and converting

```
for (const [fruit, qty] of stock) console.log(fruit, qty);
console.log([...stock.keys()], [...stock.values()], [...stock.entries()][0]);
stock.forEach((value, key) => process.stdout.write(`${key}=${value} `));

const asObject = Object.fromEntries(stock);
const backToMap = new Map(Object.entries(asObject));
console.log(asObject, backToMap.get('apples'), JSON.stringify(stock), JSON.stringify([...stock]));
```

Output:

```
apples 500
bananas 300
oranges 200
[ 'apples', 'bananas', 'oranges' ] [ 500, 300, 200 ] [ 'apples', 500 ]
apples=500 bananas=300 oranges=200
{ apples: 500, bananas: 300, oranges: 200 } 500 {} [["apples",500],["bananas",300],["oranges",200]]
```

- Note the callback order in `forEach`: **value first, then key** (matching arrays' `(element, index)`).
- `Object.fromEntries(map)` and `new Map(Object.entries(obj))` convert back and forth (only sensible when keys are strings).
- `JSON.stringify(map)` **gives** `{}` — maps are not JSON. Serialize `[...map]` (an array of pairs) or `Object.fromEntries(map)`.

Map vs Object

Feature	`Map`	Plain object `{}`
Key types	**Any value** (objects, functions, numbers, `NaN`)	Strings and symbols only (others are converted to strings)
Order	Always insertion order	Defined, but integer-like keys come first in ascending order, then strings by insertion (Ch 5)
Size	`map.size`, O(1)	`Object.keys(obj).length`, O(n)
Iteration	Directly iterable (`for…of`)	Via `Object.keys/values/entries`
Accidental keys	None — starts empty	Inherits from `Object.prototype` (`'toString' in {}`); a key named `__proto__` is special. `Object.create(null)` avoids this
Frequent add/delete	Optimised for it	`delete` can make objects slower in engines
JSON	Not directly	Native
Syntax	`map.get(k)` / `map.set(k, v)`	`obj.k` / `obj[k] = v`, literals, destructuring
Best for	Dynamic dictionaries, caches, counting, non-string keys	Fixed-shape records (`{ id, name }`), config, JSON data

Real tasks

```
const text = 'the cat and the hat and the bat';
const freq = new Map();
for (const w of text.split(' ')) freq.set(w, (freq.get(w) ?? 0) + 1);
console.log(freq, [...freq].toSorted((a, b) => b[1] - a[1])[0]);

const users = [{ id: 'u1', name: 'Ana' }, { id: 'u2', name: 'Ben' }];
const byId = new Map(users.map((u) => [u.id, u]));
console.log(byId.get('u2').name);
```

Output:

```
Map(5) { 'the' => 3, 'cat' => 1, 'and' => 2, 'hat' => 1, 'bat' => 1 } [ 'the', 3 ]
Ben
```

The **count pattern** `map.set(k, (map.get(k) ?? 0) + 1)` and the **index-by-id pattern** `new Map(list.map((x) => [x.id, x]))` turn O(n) searches into O(1) lookups. They appear constantly in interview problems (Chapter 17).

Because a Map remembers insertion order and supports cheap delete/re-insert, it makes a compact **LRU cache** (least-recently-used: when full, evict the entry unused the longest — how browser caches, CDNs and database buffer pools decide what to throw away):

```
class LRU {
  #max; #map = new Map();
  constructor(max) { this.#max = max; }
  get(k) {
    if (!this.#map.has(k)) return undefined;
    const v = this.#map.get(k); this.#map.delete(k); this.#map.set(k, v); return v;
  }
  set(k, v) {
    this.#map.delete(k); this.#map.set(k, v);
    if (this.#map.size > this.#max) this.#map.delete(this.#map.keys().next().value); // oldest
  }
  keys() { return [...this.#map.keys()]; }
}
const cache = new LRU(2);
cache.set('a', 1); cache.set('b', 2); cache.get('a'); cache.set('c', 3);
console.log(cache.keys());   // [ 'a', 'c' ]  — 'b' was least recently used
```

(The LLD handbook designs a full LRU cache with a doubly linked list: `../../../lld/`.)

Coming next — upsert (ES2026). `map.getOrInsert(key, default)` and `map.getOrInsertComputed(key, fn)` return the existing value or insert one in a single call (replacing the `has` / `get` / `set` dance). They are in the ES2026 spec but **not in Node 24**, so the demo feature-detects them and prints `false`.

Common mistakes

- Using bracket syntax on a Map: `map['k'] = 1` sets an ordinary *property* on the Map object; `map.get('k')` won't see it and `size` stays 0.
- Expecting `map.get({ id: 1 })` to find an entry stored with a *different* object that looks the same.
- `JSON.stringify(map)` → `{}`.
- Choosing a Map for a small fixed-shape record — an object is simpler and works with JSON and destructuring.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "Use a Map for dynamic key–value data: keys can be any type, it keeps insertion order, has `size`, iterates directly, and is optimised for frequent adds and deletes. Use objects for fixed-shape records and JSON. Map keys compare by SameValueZero, so objects are matched by reference."

- *How would you implement an LRU cache in JS?* A Map: on `get`, delete and re-insert; on overflow, delete `map.keys().next().value`.
- *Why not use an object as a hash map?* String-only keys, inherited properties, `__proto__` pitfalls, no `size`, slower churn.

Self-check

1. `new Map([[1, 'a']]).get('1')`? → `undefined` — `1` and `'1'` are different keys.
2. What does `map.set` return? → The map (chainable).
3. Which comes first in `map.forEach`'s callback: key or value? → Value.
4. How do you send a Map as JSON? → `JSON.stringify([...map])` or `Object.fromEntries(map)`.

8.2 `Set`

What it is

A `Set` (ES2015) holds values — primitives or object references — where each value appears **at most once**. Adding a value that is already present does nothing. Like Map, it keeps insertion order, has `size`, and uses SameValueZero equality.

Think of a guest list at a door: a name is either on it or not, and writing it twice doesn't add a second guest.

How it works

```
const colors = new Set(['red', 'green', 'blue', 'red']);
console.log(colors, colors.size);

const numbers = new Set();
numbers.add(1).add(2).add(2);                    // add is chainable; duplicates ignored
console.log(numbers.has(1), numbers.has(3), numbers.size, numbers.delete(1), numbers.delete(1), numbers);
numbers.clear();
console.log(numbers.size);
```

Output (from `code/02_set.mjs`):

```
Set(3) { 'red', 'green', 'blue' } 3
true false 2 true false Set(1) { 2 }
0
```

`new Set(iterable)` takes any iterable (array, string, another Set, a Map's keys…) and keeps the first occurrence of each value.

Member	What it does	Returns
`size` (property)	Number of values	number
`add(value)`	Adds a value if not already present	the set (chainable)
`has(value)`	Membership test — O(1) on average	boolean
`delete(value)`	Removes a value	`true` if it was present
`clear()`	Removes everything	`undefined`
`values()` / `keys()`	Iterator over values (`keys` is an alias kept for symmetry with Map)	iterator
`entries()`	Iterator of `[value, value]` pairs (again, for Map symmetry)	iterator
`forEach((value, sameValue, set) => …)`	Calls a function per value, insertion order	`undefined`
`union`, `intersection`, `difference`, `symmetricDifference`, `isSubsetOf`, `isSupersetOf`, `isDisjointFrom`	Set algebra (ES2025)	new Set / boolean

Iteration and equality

```
const s = new Set([1, 2, 3]);
s.forEach((value) => process.stdout.write(value + ' '));
console.log([...s.values()], [...s.keys()], [...s.entries()]);

const mixed = new Set([NaN, NaN, 0, -0, '1', 1, { a: 1 }, { a: 1 }]);
console.log(mixed.size, mixed);
```

Output:

```
1 2 3
[ 1, 2, 3 ] [ 1, 2, 3 ] [ [ 1, 1 ], [ 2, 2 ], [ 3, 3 ] ]
6 Set(6) { NaN, 0, '1', 1, { a: 1 }, { a: 1 } }
```

`NaN` is stored once and `0` / `-0` count as one value, but `'1'` and `1` are different, and two separate `{ a: 1 }` objects are **both** kept — objects are compared by reference. To deduplicate objects by content, key them by an id in a Map.

Classic uses

```
console.log([...new Set([3, 1, 3, 2, 1])]);           // dedupe an array, keeping first-seen order
const visited = new Set();
for (const url of ['/a', '/b', '/a', '/c', '/b']) {
  if (visited.has(url)) continue;
  visited.add(url);
}
console.log([...visited]);
```

Output:

```
[ 3, 1, 2 ]
[ '/a', '/b', '/c' ]
```

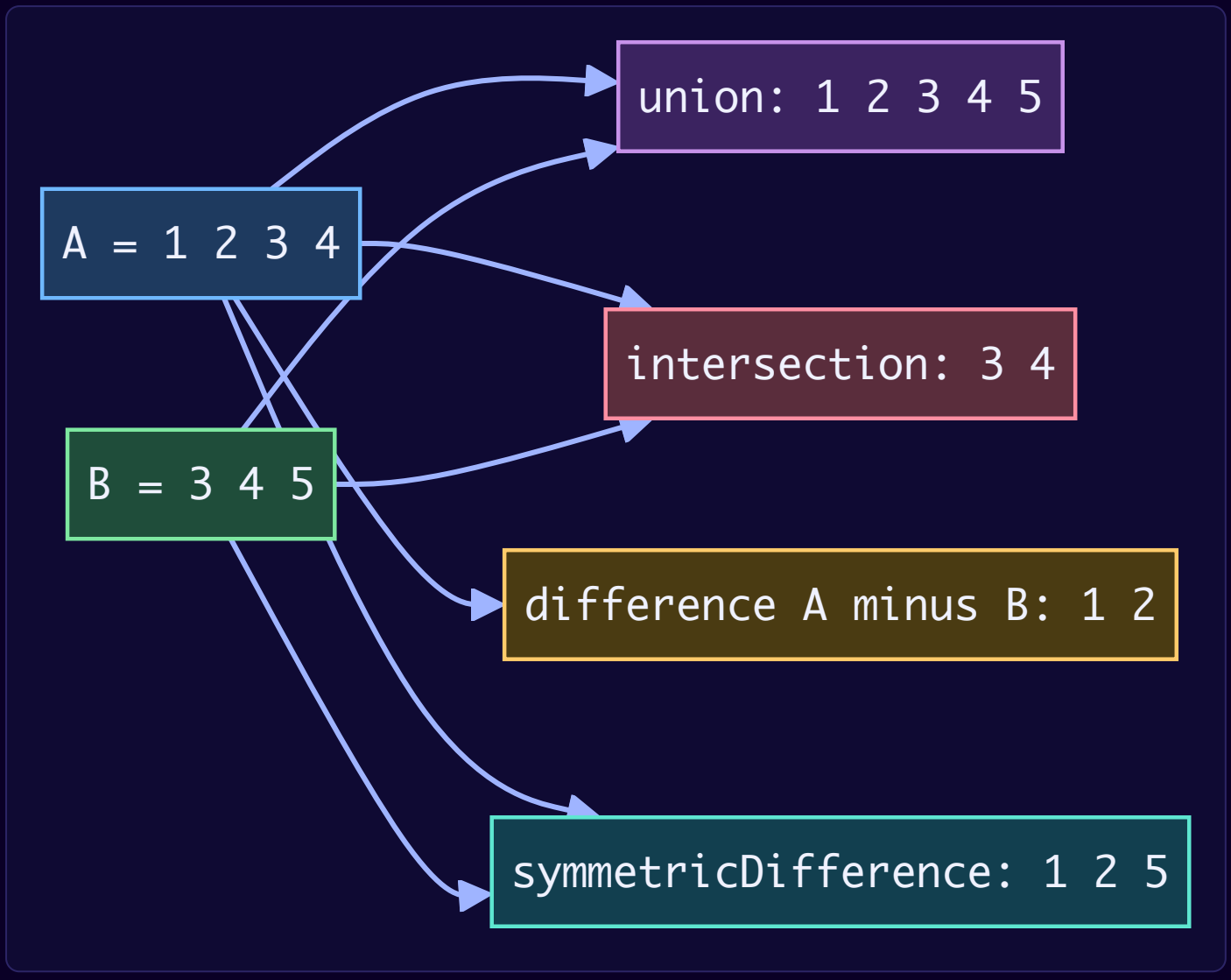
The "visited" set is the heart of web crawlers, graph searches (BFS/DFS) and "don't process this twice" logic.

Set algebra (ES2025)

```
const a = new Set([1, 2, 3, 4]);
const b = new Set([3, 4, 5]);
console.log('union              ', a.union(b));
console.log('intersection       ', a.intersection(b));
console.log('difference a-b     ', a.difference(b));
console.log('symmetricDifference', a.symmetricDifference(b));
console.log('isSubsetOf         ', new Set([3, 4]).isSubsetOf(a), a.isSupersetOf(new Set([1, 2])),
a.isDisjointFrom(new Set([9])));
```

Output:

```
union              Set(5) { 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 }
intersection       Set(2) { 3, 4 }
difference a-b     Set(2) { 1, 2 }
symmetricDifference Set(3) { 1, 2, 5 }
isSubsetOf         true true true
```



Method	Meaning	Returns
`a.union(b)`	In A **or** B	new Set
`a.intersection(b)`	In A **and** B	new Set
`a.difference(b)`	In A but **not** B	new Set
`a.symmetricDifference(b)`	In exactly one of them	new Set
`a.isSubsetOf(b)`	Every element of A is in B	boolean
`a.isSupersetOf(b)`	Every element of B is in A	boolean
`a.isDisjointFrom(b)`	No shared elements	boolean

These methods were standardized in **ES2025** and are available in all current browsers and in **Node 22+**. None of them mutates `a` or `b`. The argument doesn't have to be a Set — any **set-like** object (one with `size`, `has()` and `keys()`) works, such as a Map (its keys are used):

```
const allowed = new Map([['read', true], ['write', false]]);
console.log(new Set(['read', 'delete']).intersection(allowed));   // Set(1) { 'read' }
```

On older runtimes, the classic pattern converts to an array and filters:

```
const setA = new Set([1, 2, 3]);
const setB = new Set([2, 3, 4]);
const intersection = new Set([...setA].filter((x) => setB.has(x)));
console.log(intersection);   // Set(2) { 2, 3 }
```

Similarly, union is `new Set([...a, ...b])` and difference is `new Set([...a].filter((x) => !b.has(x)))`.

Performance: `Set.has` vs `Array.includes`

`array.includes(x)` scans elements one by one — **O(n)**. `set.has(x)` uses hashing — **O(1)** on average. The demo checks 2,000 lookups against 200,000 numbers and confirms `Set.has` is faster (the exact timing varies by machine, so the script prints only the comparison). Rule of thumb: if you test membership repeatedly, build a Set once.

Common mistakes

- Expecting a Set to deduplicate objects with equal contents.
- Using `set[0]` — Sets have no indexes; convert with `[...set]` or iterate.
- Forgetting that `new Set('hello')` iterates the string: `Set { 'h', 'e', 'l', 'o' }`.
- Calling `JSON.stringify(set)` → `{}`; send `[...set]`.

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "A Set stores unique values by SameValueZero, keeps insertion order and gives O(1) average `has`. I use it to dedupe (`[...new Set(arr)]`), track visited nodes, and — since ES2025 — for set algebra with `union`, `intersection`, `difference` and friends."

- *Remove duplicates from an array of objects by id?* `[...new Map(arr.map((o) => [o.id, o])).values()]` (keeps the last of each id).
- *Intersection of two arrays in O(n + m)?* `const s = new Set(b); a.filter((x) => s.has(x))`.

Self-check

1. `new Set([1, '1', 1]).size`? → 2.
2. What does `set.add(x)` return? → The set.
3. `new Set([1,2]).union(new Set([2,3]))`? → `Set {1, 2, 3}`.

4. Why is `set.has` better than `arr.includes` in a loop? → O(1) vs O(n) per check.

8.3 `WeakMap`, `WeakSet`, `WeakRef` and `FinalizationRegistry`

What it is

JavaScript frees memory automatically with a **garbage collector** (GC): an object is removed once nothing **reachable** refers to it. A normal Map or Set holds a **strong** reference to its keys/values, so storing an object in a Map keeps it alive forever — a classic memory leak. The **weak** collections hold their keys **weakly**: the entry does not stop the object from being collected, and when it is collected, the entry quietly disappears.

How they work

	`WeakMap`	`WeakSet`	`WeakRef` (ES2021)	`FinalizationRegistry` (ES2021)
Holds	key (weakly) → value	values (weakly)	one target (weakly)	callbacks for targets
Allowed keys/targets	Objects, and non-registered symbols (ES2023)	Same	Same	Same
Methods	`set`, `get`, `has`, `delete`	`add`, `has`, `delete`	`deref()` → target or `undefined`	`register`, `unregister`
`size`, iteration, `clear`	**No**	**No**	–	–

Why no `size` or iteration? Because the contents change whenever the GC runs, which is unpredictable; exposing them would make programs behave differently from run to run.

From `code/03_weak_collections.mjs`:

```
const metadata = new WeakMap();
function track(el) { metadata.set(el, { clicks: 0, firstSeen: 'now' }); }
const button = { tag: 'button' };               // imagine a DOM element
track(button);
metadata.get(button).clicks++;
console.log(metadata.get(button), metadata.has(button), metadata.has({ tag: 'button' }));

const areaCache = new WeakMap();
let computed = 0;
function area(shape) {
  if (!areaCache.has(shape)) { computed++; areaCache.set(shape, shape.w * shape.h); }
  return areaCache.get(shape);
}
const box = { w: 3, h: 4 };
console.log(area(box), area(box), 'computed', computed, 'time(s)');

const processed = new WeakSet();
function processOnce(job) {
  if (processed.has(job)) return 'skipped';
  processed.add(job); return 'processed';
}
const job = { id: 7 };
console.log(processOnce(job), processOnce(job));

try { new WeakMap().set('str', 1); } catch (e) { console.log('primitive key ->', e.constructor.name); }
const wm = new WeakMap();
console.log('size' in wm, typeof wm[Symbol.iterator], typeof wm.keys);
const sym = Symbol('local');
console.log(new WeakMap([[sym, 'symbol key ok (ES2023)']]).get(sym));
try { new WeakSet().add(Symbol.for('registered')); } catch (e) { console.log('registered symbol ->',
e.constructor.name); }
```

Output:

```
{ clicks: 1, firstSeen: 'now' } true false
12 12 computed 1 time(s)
processed skipped
primitive key -> TypeError
false undefined undefined
symbol key ok (ES2023)
registered symbol -> TypeError
```

Three standard uses:

1. **Side tables** – attach extra data to objects you don't own (DOM elements, objects from a library) without adding properties to them. When the element is removed from the page and dropped, its data goes too.
2. **Memoization caches keyed by object** – cache a computed result per object; no manual eviction needed.
3. **Tagging/branding** with a WeakSet – "have I already processed / validated / created this object?" (This is how some libraries implemented private state before class `#private` fields existed.)

Primitive keys are rejected because primitives are never garbage collected; symbols created with `Symbol.for` (the global registry) are rejected for the same reason.

`WeakRef` and `FinalizationRegistry`

```
let bigObject = { payload: 'x'.repeat(10) };
const ref = new WeakRef(bigObject);
console.log(ref.deref()?.payload.length);        // still reachable -> 10
bigObject = null;                                // after GC, deref() MAY return undefined

const registry = new FinalizationRegistry((heldValue) => console.log('cleaned up', heldValue));
registry.register({ temp: true }, 'temp-object');
```

A `WeakRef` lets you point at an object *without* keeping it alive; `deref()` returns the object or `undefined` once collected. A `FinalizationRegistry` asks to be called back some time after a registered object is collected. Both are advanced tools for caches of large objects and for releasing external resources. Their timing is **unspecified** — the callback may run late or never (for example when the program exits first) — so never put essential logic (saving data, closing files) in them. The TC39 proposal itself advises avoiding them where possible.

When not to use it

- You need to list, count or iterate the entries → use `Map` / `Set` and remove entries yourself.
- Your keys are strings or numbers → weak collections can't hold them.

In the interview

- *Difference between Map and WeakMap?* WeakMap keys must be objects (or non-registered symbols) and are held weakly, so entries vanish when the key is garbage-collected; as a result it has no `size`, no iteration and no `clear`.
- *Give a real use.* Caching computed data per DOM node or per request object; private per-instance data.

Self-check

1. Can a WeakMap have a string key? → No — `TypeError`.
2. Why can't you iterate a WeakSet? → Its contents depend on unpredictable GC timing.
3. What does `weakRef.deref()` return after the target is collected? → `undefined`.

8.4 Iterators and the iterable protocol

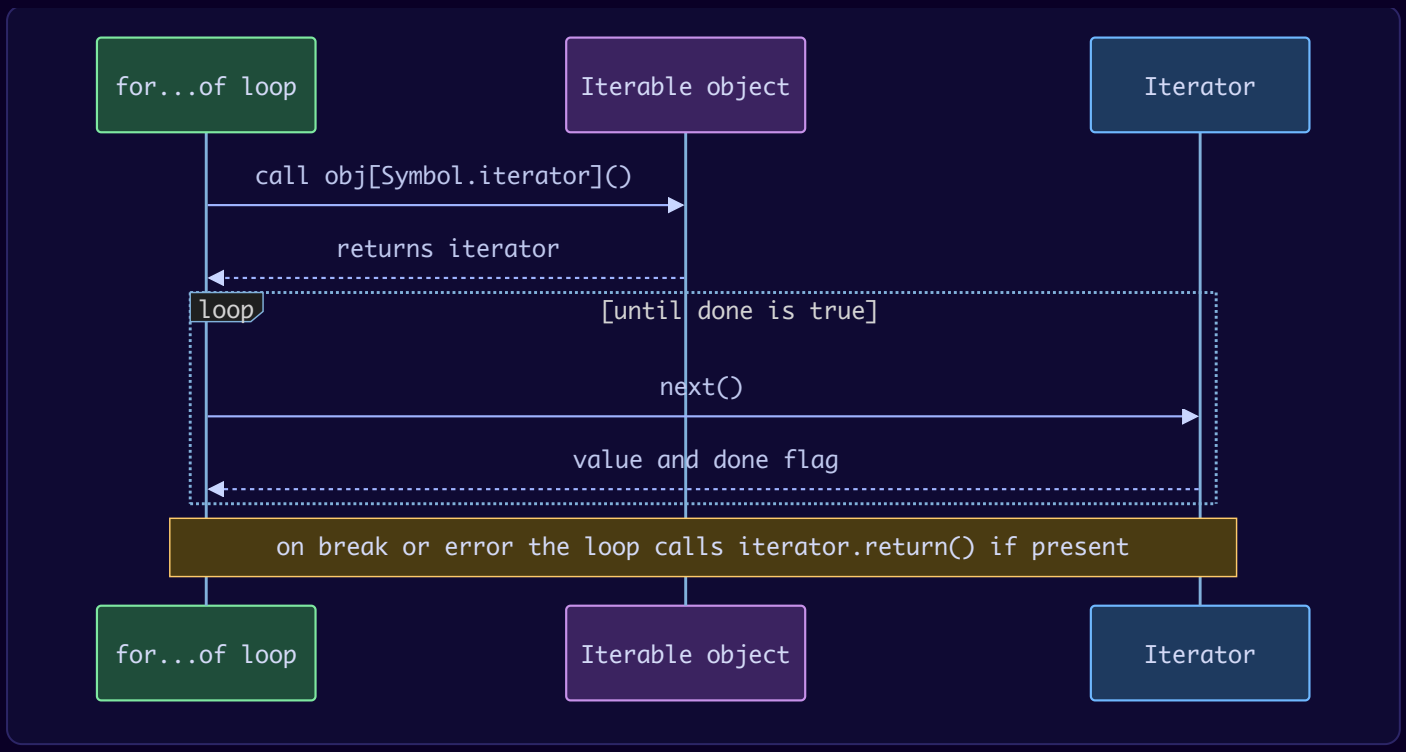
What it is

Two small **protocols** (agreed-upon shapes of objects, ES2015) make `for…of`, spread, destructuring, `Array.from`, `new Map(…)`, `new Set(…)`, `Promise.all` and more work on *any* collection:

- An **iterator** is an object with a `next()` method that hands back a `{ value, done }` result on every call; a result with `done: true` signals the end of the sequence.
- An **iterable** is an object with a method under the key `Symbol.iterator` that returns a fresh iterator.

`Symbol.iterator` is a **well-known symbol**: a built-in unique key the language itself looks for. Using a symbol (instead of a string like `"iterator"`) guarantees it can't clash with ordinary property names.

Think of an iterable as a book and an iterator as a bookmark: you can open the same book many times, each time with a new bookmark that only moves forward.



How it works — driving it by hand

From `code/04_iterators.mjs`:

```
const it = ['a', 'b'][Symbol.iterator]();
console.log(it.next(), it.next(), it.next());

const isIterable = (x) => x != null && typeof x[Symbol.iterator] === 'function';
console.log([['array', [1]], ['string', 'hi'], ['Map', new Map()], ['Set', new Set()], ['object', {}],
['number', 5]]
  .map(([n, v]) => `${n}:${isIterable(v)}`).join(' '));
```

Output:

```
{ value: 'a', done: false } { value: 'b', done: false } { value: undefined, done: true }
array:true string:true Map:true Set:true object:false number:false
```

Built-in iterables: **arrays, strings, Maps, Sets, typed arrays,** `arguments`, DOM `NodeList`**s, generator objects**, and the iterators returned by `keys()` / `values()` / `entries()`. Plain objects are **not** iterable — that's why you write `for (const [k, v] of Object.entries(obj))`.

Making your own iterable

```
const countdown = {
  from: 3,
  [Symbol.iterator]() {
    let current = this.from;
    return {
      next: () => (current > 0 ? { value: current--, done: false } : { value: undefined, done: true }),
      [Symbol.iterator]() { return this; },           // iterators are usually iterable too
    };
  },
};
console.log([...countdown], Array.from(countdown), Math.max(...countdown));
for (const n of countdown) process.stdout.write(n + ' ');
console.log('liftoff');
const [first, ...others] = countdown;
console.log(first, others, new Set(countdown).size, new Map([[1, 'x']]).size);
```

Output:

```
[ 3, 2, 1 ] [ 3, 2, 1 ] 3
3 2 1 liftoff
3 [ 2, 1 ] 3 1
```

1. `[Symbol.iterator]()` is a **computed method name** (Chapter 5): the key is the symbol.
2. Each call creates a new iterator with its own `current` (a closure), so the object can be iterated many times.
3. Every consumer — spread, `Array.from`, `Math.max(...)`, `for…of`, destructuring, `new Set` — now works automatically.

Writing `next()` by hand is verbose; a **generator** does the same in two lines (the `Range` class in the demo uses `*[Symbol.iterator]() { … yield v; }` and prints `[ 0, 3, 6, 9 ]` — section 8.5).

Early exit and `return()`

If a consumer stops before `done` (a `break`, a `return`, an exception, or destructuring that takes only the first few values), it calls the iterator's optional `return()` method, which is where cleanup (closing a file, releasing a lock) belongs:

```
function resource() {
  let i = 0;
  return {
    [Symbol.iterator]() { return this; },
    next() { i++; return { value: i, done: i > 5 }; },
    return() { console.log('  cleanup after', i, 'items'); return { done: true }; },
  };
}
for (const x of resource()) { if (x === 2) break; }
const [one] = resource();
console.log('first item was', one);
```

Output:

```
  cleanup after 2 items
  cleanup after 1 items
first item was 1
```

Iterators are single-use

```
const arr = [1, 2];
const once = arr.values();
console.log([...once], [...once], [...arr], [...arr]);
```

Output:

```
[ 1, 2 ] [] [ 1, 2 ] [ 1, 2 ]
```

An **iterator** is exhausted after one pass; an **iterable** (the array) hands out a fresh iterator each time. Passing an iterator where code expects to loop twice is a subtle bug.

Everything that consumes iterables

Consumer	Example
`for…of`	`for (const x of set)`
Spread in arrays and calls	`[...map]`, `Math.max(...set)`
Array destructuring	`const [a, b] = iterable`
`Array.from(iterable, mapFn?)`	`Array.from(map.values())`
Collection constructors	`new Map(pairs)`, `new Set(values)`, `new WeakMap(pairs)`
`Object.fromEntries(pairs)`	`Object.fromEntries(map)`
Promise combinators	`Promise.all(iterable)`, `allSettled`, `race`, `any`
`yield*`	inside generators
Grouping	`Object.groupBy(iterable, fn)`

In the interview

> **30-second answer:** "An iterable has a `[Symbol.iterator]()` method returning an iterator; an iterator has `next()` returning `{ value, done }`. `for…of`, spread, destructuring, `Array.from` and the Map/Set constructors all speak this protocol, so implementing it makes any object work with them. Iterators can also define `return()` for cleanup on early exit."

- *Why isn't a plain object iterable?* Its keys, values and entries are all reasonable things to iterate, so the language makes you choose with `Object.keys/values/entries`.
- *`for…in` vs `for…of`?* `for…in` walks enumerable property **keys** (including inherited ones); `for…of` walks the **values** an iterable produces (Chapter 3).

Self-check

1. What must `next()` return? → An object `{ value, done }`.
2. Why does `[...{a: 1}]` throw? → Plain objects are not iterable.
3. When is `return()` called? → When a consumer stops early (break, throw, partial destructuring).

8.5 Generators

What it is

A **generator function** (`function*`, ES2015) is a function that can **pause** in the middle and **resume** later. Calling it doesn't run its body; it returns a **generator object**, which is both an iterator and an iterable. Each `next()` call runs the body until the next `yield`, which hands out a value and pauses right there.

Think of a generator as a TV series rather than a film: calling it gives you the box set, and each `next()` plays one more episode, remembering where you stopped.

How it works

From `code/05_generators.mjs`:

```
function* threeSteps() {
  console.log('  start');
  yield 1;
  console.log('  after first yield');
  yield 2;
  console.log('  after second yield');
  return 3;                                   // return value is NOT included by for...of / spread
}
const gen = threeSteps();                     // nothing runs yet
console.log('created');
console.log(gen.next());
console.log(gen.next());
console.log(gen.next());
console.log(gen.next());
console.log([...threeSteps()]);
```

Output:

```
created
  start
{ value: 1, done: false }
  after first yield
{ value: 2, done: false }
  after second yield
{ value: 3, done: true }
{ value: undefined, done: true }
  start
  after first yield
  after second yield
[ 1, 2 ]
```

Step by step:

1. `threeSteps()` returns a generator object; **no code in the body runs** (`created` prints first).
2. The first `next()` runs until `yield 1` and pauses → `{ value: 1, done: false }`.
3. Each further `next()` resumes right after the last `yield`.
4. `return 3` finishes the generator → `{ value: 3, done: true }`. After that, `next()` always gives `{ value: undefined, done: true }`.
5. `for…of` and spread stop as soon as `done` is `true`, so they **ignore the return value** – `[1, 2]`, not `[1, 2, 3]`.

Syntax variants: `function* name() {}`, `const g = function* () {}`, methods `*name() {}` in objects/classes, and `*[Symbol.iterator]() {}`. There are **no arrow generators**.

Lazy and infinite sequences

Because values are produced only when requested, a generator can describe an **infinite** sequence safely – as long as the consumer stops.

```
function* naturals() { let n = 1; while (true) yield n++; }
function* take(iterable, n) {
  if (n <= 0) return;
  for (const x of iterable) { yield x; if (--n <= 0) return; }
}
console.log([...take(naturals(), 5)]);

function* fibonacci() { let [a, b] = [0, 1]; while (true) { yield a; [a, b] = [b, a + b]; } }
console.log([...take(fibonacci(), 10)]);

function* map(iter, fn) { for (const x of iter) yield fn(x); }
function* filter(iter, pred) { for (const x of iter) if (pred(x)) yield x; }
const firstSquaresOfOdds = take(map(filter(naturals(), (n) => n % 2), (n) => n * n), 4);
console.log([...firstSquaresOfOdds]);
```

Output:

```
[ 1, 2, 3, 4, 5 ]
[
  0, 1,  1,  2,  3,
  5, 8, 13, 21, 34
]
[ 1, 9, 25, 49 ]
```

The pipeline processes **one value at a time** through `filter → map → take` and never builds an intermediate array — the same "lazy evaluation" idea as Python generators, Java streams or Unix pipes. It's how you'd process a huge log file line by line without loading it all into memory. Section 8.6 shows the built-in version.

Delegation with `yield*` and recursion

```
function* inner() { yield 'b'; yield 'c'; return 'inner-done'; }
function* outer() { yield 'a'; const r = yield* inner(); yield r; yield* [1, 2]; }
console.log([...outer()]);

const tree = { value: 1, children: [{ value: 2, children: [{ value: 4, children: [] }] }, { value: 3,
children: [] }] };
function* depthFirst(node) { yield node.value; for (const c of node.children) yield* depthFirst(c); }
console.log([...depthFirst(tree)]);
```

Output:

```
[ 'a', 'b', 'c', 'inner-done', 1, 2 ]
[ 1, 2, 4, 3 ]
```

`yield* iterable` yields every value of another iterable (a generator, an array, a string…) as if they were yielded here, and evaluates to that generator's **return value**. Combined with recursion, it makes tree and graph traversal read almost like the definition: "yield this node, then everything from each child".

Two-way communication: `next(value)`, `return()`, `throw()`

```
function* runningAverage() {
  let sum = 0, count = 0, avg;
  while (true) {
    const value = yield avg;
    sum += value; count++; avg = sum / count;
  }
}
const avg = runningAverage();
avg.next();                                  // prime: run to the first yield
console.log(avg.next(10).value, avg.next(20).value, avg.next(60).value);

function* guarded() {
  try { yield 1; yield 2; } finally { console.log('  finally ran'); }
}
const g1 = guarded(); g1.next();
console.log(g1.return('stopped'), g1.next());
const g2 = guarded(); g2.next();
try { g2.throw(new Error('boom')); } catch (e) { console.log('caught outside:', e.message); }
```

Output:

```
10 15 30
  finally ran
{ value: 'stopped', done: true } { value: undefined, done: true }
  finally ran
caught outside: boom
```

- `gen.next(x)` resumes the generator and makes the paused `yield` expression evaluate to `x`. The first `next()` only runs up to the first `yield` (any argument to it is ignored), so it "primes" the generator.
- `gen.return(v)` finishes the generator as if a `return v` happened at the paused `yield` — `finally` blocks still run.
- `gen.throw(err)` throws `err` at the paused `yield`; if the generator doesn't catch it, it propagates to the caller.

This two-way channel is how libraries like **redux-saga** drive effects, and how `async`/`await` was emulated before ES2017 (the `co` library ran generators that yielded promises — see Chapter 12).

More uses: ID makers, state machines, async paging

```
function* idMaker(prefix) { let i = 0; while (true) yield `${prefix}-${++i}`; }
const ids = idMaker('order');
console.log(ids.next().value, ids.next().value);

function* trafficLight() { while (true) { yield 'green'; yield 'yellow'; yield 'red'; } }
const light = trafficLight();
console.log(Array.from({ length: 5 }, () => light.next().value));

async function* fetchPages(totalPages) {
  for (let page = 1; page <= totalPages; page++) {
    await new Promise((r) => setTimeout(r, 5));          // pretend network call
    yield { page, items: [`item${page * 2 - 1}`, `item${page * 2}`] };
  }
}
for await (const { page, items } of fetchPages(3)) console.log('page', page, items);
console.log(await Array.fromAsync(fetchPages(2), (p) => p.page));
```

Output:

```
order-1 order-2
[ 'green', 'yellow', 'red', 'green', 'yellow' ]
page 1 [ 'item1', 'item2' ]
page 2 [ 'item3', 'item4' ]
page 3 [ 'item5', 'item6' ]
[ 1, 2 ]
```

An **async generator** (`async function*`, ES2018) can `await` inside and is consumed with `for await…of`. It's the natural shape for paginated APIs, reading streams chunk by chunk (Node's readable streams are async iterables – Chapter 15), or polling. `Array.fromAsync` (ES2026, already in Node 24) collects an async iterable into an array.

Trade-offs

	Generator	Array
Memory	One value at a time	All values at once
Infinite sequences	Yes	No
Random access `[i]`, `length`	No	Yes
Reusable	No – create a new generator each time	Yes
Speed for small data	Slightly slower (pause/resume overhead)	Faster

When not to use it

For small, finite data that you'll index, sort or iterate several times, just build an array. Generators shine for large, lazy, infinite or step-by-step data, and for implementing `[Symbol.iterator]`.

Common mistakes

- Calling a generator and expecting its body to run (`gen()` alone does nothing).
- Expecting the `return` value to appear in `for…of` or spread results.
- Reusing an exhausted generator object.
- Spreading an infinite generator without `take` → the program never ends (and runs out of memory).
- Forgetting to prime a generator before sending values with `next(x)`.

In the interview

30-second answer: "A `function*` returns a generator object that's both an iterator and an iterable. `yield` pauses and emits a value; `next()` resumes. That makes lazy and infinite sequences easy, lets you implement `Symbol.iterator` in two lines, and supports two-way communication via `next(x)`, `return` and `throw`. Async generators with `for await` handle paginated or streamed data."

- *Write a `range(start, end)` generator.* `function* range(s, e) { for (let i = s; i < e; i++) yield i; }`
- *What's `yield*`?* Delegation: yields all values from another iterable and evaluates to its return value.
- *How do generators relate to async/await?* Async functions behave like generators that yield promises and are resumed when each settles.

Self-check

1. What does `[...(function* () { yield 1; return 2; })()]` produce? → `[1]`.
2. What does the first `next()` call do? → Runs to the first `yield` (or the end).
3. Can arrow functions be generators? → No.
4. How do you consume an async generator? → `for await (const x of gen())` or `Array.fromAsync`.

8.6 Iterator helpers (ES2025)

What it is

Iterator helpers add array-like methods – `map`, `filter`, `take`, `drop`, `flatMap`, `reduce`, `toArray`, `forEach`, `some`, `every`, `find` – directly to **iterators** (via a new global `Iterator` class whose prototype every built-in iterator inherits from). Unlike the array methods, the ones that return iterators are **lazy**: nothing is computed until you pull values. Standardized in **ES2025**; available in Node 22+ and all current browsers.

From `code/06_iterator_helpers.mjs`:

```
function* naturals() { let n = 1; while (true) yield n++; }

const result = naturals()
  .filter((n) => n % 3 === 0)
  .map((n) => n * n)
  .take(4)
  .toArray();
console.log(result);

let pulled = 0;
const lazy = naturals().map((n) => { pulled++; return n * 10; }).take(3);
console.log('pulled before use:', pulled);
console.log([...lazy], 'pulled after use:', pulled);

console.log(naturals().drop(5).take(3).toArray());
console.log(['a b', 'c'].values().flatMap((s) => s.split(' ')).toArray());
console.log(naturals().take(5).reduce((sum, n) => sum + n, 0));
console.log(naturals().some((n) => n > 1000), naturals().take(3).every((n) => n < 5), naturals().find((n) => n
* n > 50));

const prices = new Map([['tea', 3], ['cake', 5], ['pie', 7]]);
console.log(prices.entries().filter(([, p]) => p > 4).map(([k]) => k).toArray());

const plain = { i: 0, next() { return this.i < 3 ? { value: this.i++, done: false } : { value: undefined,
done: true }; } };
console.log(Iterator.from(plain).map((x) => x + 100).toArray());

const arr = [1, 2, 3, 4];
console.log(typeof arr.take, arr.values().take(2).toArray());
```

Output:

```
[ 9, 36, 81, 144 ]
pulled before use: 0
[ 10, 20, 30 ] pulled after use: 3
[ 6, 7, 8 ]
[ 'a', 'b', 'c' ]
15
true true 8
[ 'cake', 'pie' ]
[ 100, 101, 102 ]
undefined [ 1, 2 ]
```

Helper	Lazy?	Returns
`map(fn)`, `filter(fn)`, `flatMap(fn)`	Yes	iterator
`take(n)`, `drop(n)`	Yes	iterator
`toArray()`	No — consumes	array
`reduce(fn, init?)`, `forEach(fn)`	No — consumes	value / `undefined`
`some(fn)`, `every(fn)`, `find(fn)`	No — consumes, **short-circuits**	boolean / value
`Iterator.from(obj)` (static)	—	wraps any iterator or iterable so helpers are available

Key points:

- It works on an **infinite** generator because `take(4)` stops pulling once it has four results; `pulled` proves `map` ran only 3 times.
- Map and Set iterators (`entries()`, `values()`) get the helpers too — no need to spread into an array first.
- **Arrays are iterables, not iterators**: `arr.take` is `undefined`. Call `arr.values()` to get the lazy helpers. For ordinary array work, the array methods (Chapter 7) are simpler; use iterator helpers for large, lazy or infinite data.
- **`Iterator.concat`** (joining several iterators, ES2026) is not in Node 24 — the demo feature-detects it. **Async** iterator helpers are still a separate proposal.

8.7 Grouping: `Object.groupBy` and `Map.groupBy` (ES2024)

What it is

Two static methods that take an iterable and a **key function**, and put each item into the bucket named by the key it returns. Standardized in **ES2024**; in Node 21+ and all current browsers. (They were first proposed as `Array.prototype.group`, but that name broke existing websites, so they became static methods.)

- `Object.groupBy(items, fn)` → a **null-prototype object** whose keys are strings (the key function's results converted to strings).
- `Map.groupBy(items, fn)` → a **`Map`**, so keys keep their type — objects, numbers, anything.

From `code/07_groupby.mjs`:

```
const inventory = [
  { name: 'laptop', type: 'electronics', quantity: 4 },
  { name: 'desk', type: 'furniture', quantity: 0 },
  { name: 'monitor', type: 'electronics', quantity: 12 },
  { name: 'chair', type: 'furniture', quantity: 30 },
  { name: 'stapler', type: 'office', quantity: 5 },
];

const byType = Object.groupBy(inventory, (item) => item.type);
console.log(Object.keys(byType), byType.furniture.map((i) => i.name));
console.log(Object.getPrototypeOf(byType) === null);

const byStock = Object.groupBy(inventory, ({ quantity }) => (quantity > 5 ? 'ok' : 'restock'));
console.log(Object.fromEntries(Object.entries(byStock).map(([k, v]) => [k, v.map((i) => i.name)])));

const restock = { label: 'restock' }, sufficient = { label: 'sufficient' };
const byObjectKey = Map.groupBy(inventory, ({ quantity }) => (quantity < 6 ? restock : sufficient));
console.log(byObjectKey.get(restock).map((i) => i.name));
const byLength = Map.groupBy(['a', 'bb', 'cc', 'ddd'], (w) => w.length);
console.log(byLength, byLength.get(2));

console.log(Object.groupBy(new Set([1, 2, 3, 4, 5]), (n) => (n % 2 ? 'odd' : 'even')));

const legacy = inventory.reduce((acc, item) => { (acc[item.type] ??= []).push(item.name); return acc; }, {});
console.log(legacy);
```

Output:

```
[ 'electronics', 'furniture', 'office' ] [ 'desk', 'chair' ]
true
{
  restock: [ 'laptop', 'desk', 'stapler' ],
  ok: [ 'monitor', 'chair' ]
}
[ 'laptop', 'desk', 'stapler' ]
Map(3) { 1 => [ 'a' ], 2 => [ 'bb', 'cc' ], 3 => [ 'ddd' ] } [ 'bb', 'cc' ]
[Object: null prototype] { odd: [ 1, 3, 5 ], even: [ 2, 4 ] }
{
  electronics: [ 'laptop', 'monitor' ],
  furniture: [ 'desk', 'chair' ],
  office: [ 'stapler' ]
}
```

How it works:

1. Walk the iterable in order.
2. Call `fn(item, index)` to get a key.
3. Append the item to that key's array (creating it the first time).
4. Group order follows the first time each key appears; items inside a group keep their original order.

The result's **null prototype** means there are no inherited keys (a group named `toString` or `constructor` is safe), but also no inherited methods — use `Object.keys(result)`, not `result.hasOwnProperty(...)`. The grouped arrays contain the **original items** (not copies).

Before ES2024 everyone wrote the `reduce` version with `??=` (logical nullish assignment: assign only if the left side is `null` / `undefined`); lodash's `_.groupBy` is the library equivalent.

Trade-offs

	`Object.groupBy`	`Map.groupBy`
Keys	Strings (and symbols)	Any value
Result	Null-prototype object	Map
JSON-friendly	Yes	Convert first
Destructuring `const { ok, restock } = …`	Yes	No
Use when	Grouping by a label/category	Grouping by object, number, or you need Map features

Real-world examples

- Dashboards: group orders by status or by day before rendering sections.
- Chat apps: group messages by date ("Today", "Yesterday").
- Data cleanup: group records by email to find duplicates.
- Counting per group: `Object.fromEntries(Object.entries(byType).map(([k, v]) => [k, v.length]))` → `{ electronics: 2, furniture: 2, office: 1 }`.

In the interview

- *How do you group an array by a property?* `Object.groupBy(arr, (x) => x.prop)` in modern runtimes; `reduce` with `(acc[k] ??= []).push(x)` otherwise.
- *When `Map.groupBy` over `Object.groupBy`?* Non-string keys, or when you need Map semantics (order, `size`, object keys).

Self-check

1. Is `groupBy` a method on arrays? → No — static: `Object.groupBy(items, fn)` / `Map.groupBy(items, fn)`.
2. What prototype does `Object.groupBy`'s result have? → `null`.
3. Group numbers into even/odd with a Map. → `Map.groupBy(nums, (n) => n % 2 === 0)` (keys `true` / `false`).

Version summary (verified September 2026)

Feature	Standard	Node 24	Notes
`Map`, `Set`, `WeakMap`, `WeakSet`, iterators, generators	ES2015	✓	
Async generators, `for await…of`	ES2018	✓	
`WeakRef`, `FinalizationRegistry`	ES2021	✓	Timing unspecified
Symbols as WeakMap keys	ES2023	✓	Non-registered symbols only
`Object.groupBy`, `Map.groupBy`	ES2024	✓	Node 21+
Set methods (`union`, `intersection`, …)	ES2025	✓	Node 22+
Iterator helpers, `Iterator.from`	ES2025	✓	Node 22+
`Array.fromAsync`	ES2026	✓	
`Map/WeakMap.prototype.getOrInsert(Computed)` (upsert)	ES2026	✗	Feature-detect
`Iterator.concat`	ES2026	✗	Feature-detect

Chapter TL;DR

- **Map**: key → value with keys of any type (SameValueZero), insertion order, `size`, direct iteration; `set` (chainable, updates), `get`, `has`, `delete`, `clear`, `keys/values/entries`, `forEach(value, key)`. Prefer it for dynamic dictionaries, counting, caches (LRU), non-string keys; prefer objects for fixed records and JSON. `JSON.stringify(map)` is `{}`.
- **Set**: unique values, insertion order, O(1) `has`; `add` (chainable), `delete`, `clear`, `values`, `entries` (`[v, v]`), `forEach`. Dedupe with `[...new Set(arr)]`. ES2025 adds `union`, `intersection`, `difference`, `symmetricDifference`, `isSubsetOf`, `isSupersetOf`, `isDisjointFrom`.
- **WeakMap/WeakSet** hold object (or non-registered symbol) keys weakly: no leaks, but no `size`/iteration. Use for side tables, per-object caches, tagging. **WeakRef/FinalizationRegistry** are advanced; never rely on their timing.
- **Iterable** = has `[Symbol.iterator]()` returning an **iterator** with `next() → { value, done }` (optional `return()` for cleanup). Arrays, strings, Maps, Sets, typed arrays, NodeLists and generators are iterable; plain objects aren't. Consumers: `for…of`, spread, destructuring, `Array.from`, Map/Set constructors, `Promise.all`.
- **Generators** (`function*`) pause at `yield`; calling one returns an iterator without running the body. Great for lazy/infinite sequences, `Symbol.iterator`, tree traversal (`yield*`), two-way coroutines (`next(x)`, `return`, `throw`). **Async generators** + `for await…of` for paged or streamed data.
- **Iterator helpers** (ES2025): lazy `map/filter/take/drop/flatMap` and consuming `toArray/reduce/forEach/some/every/find` on any iterator; `Iterator.from` wraps custom ones; arrays need `.values()` first.
- `Object.groupBy` / `Map.groupBy` (ES2024) bucket items by a key function — null-prototype object with string keys, or a Map with any keys.